

Six Points Demands of 1966

The Six Point Movement was a historic political campaign in 1966 led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman in East Pakistan that demanded greater regional autonomy to end decades of economic and political exploitation by West Pakistani rulers. Widely remembered as the "Magna Carta" or "Charter of Freedom" of the Bengali nation, this movement served as the foundational stepping stone toward the 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War.

Historical Background:

The Six Point Movement was a historic political campaign launched in 1966 by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and the Awami League. Designed as a "charter of freedom," its primary goal was to end the political and economic exploitation of East Pakistan by the West Pakistani ruling establishment by securing regional autonomy.

A STATISTICAL OVERVIEW OF ECONOMIC INEQUALITY AGAINST BENGALI NATION				
Year	Spending on West Pakistan (in core rupees)	Amount spent on West as percentage of total	Spending on East Pakistan (in core rupees)	Amount spent on East as percentage of total
1950–55	1,129	68.31	524	31.69
1955–60	1,655	75.95	524	24.05
1960–65	3,355	70.5	1,404	29.5
1965–70	5,195	70.82	2,141	29.18
Total	11,334	71.16	4,593	28.84

Source: Reports of the Advisory Panels for the Fourth Five Year Plan 1970–75, Vol. I, published by the planning commission of Pakistan

Core Background Factors:

- **Severe Economic Disparity:** Despite generating the majority of Pakistan's export revenue (primarily through jute), East Pakistan received a disproportionately small share of the national budget and foreign aid. This resulted in severe underdevelopment, a massive wealth gap, and rampant inflation in the East.
- **The 1965 Indo-Pak War:** During the 1965 war, East Pakistan was left virtually defenseless with no military assets allocated for its protection. This stark realization of geographical and defensive vulnerability deeply angered the Bengali populace, fueling a demand for a regional paramilitary force.
- **Political Marginalization:** West Pakistan held all central government, military, and bureaucratic power, effectively treating East Pakistan as a colony. Bengalis, despite making up the majority of the country's population, were continuously sidelined in democratic decision-making.
- **The Cultural & Language Struggle:** The Six Points built directly on the momentum of the 1952 Language Movement. The people of East Pakistan recognized that their

linguistic and cultural identity was under constant threat from the central government's efforts to homogenize Pakistan.

The Six Points Explained:

The charter sought a radical restructuring of Pakistan's governance to return power to the provinces:

1. Federal Constitution: A true federation based on the 1940 Lahore Resolution, featuring a parliamentary form of government with a legislature elected directly by universal adult franchise.
2. Central Government Powers: The federal government would manage only two portfolios: Defense and Foreign Affairs. All other residual subjects would reside with the federating states.
3. Commodity and Currency: Two separate but freely convertible currencies for the two wings, or a single currency with strict constitutional mechanisms to stop the flight of capital from East to West Pakistan.
4. Fiscal and Taxation Power: The power of taxation and revenue collection would vest entirely with the federating units, leaving the federal center to rely on a fixed share of regional revenues.
5. Foreign Exchange Accounts: Separate foreign exchange earning accounts for both wings, giving East Pakistan the autonomy to establish its own international trade and aid links.
6. Regional Militia: The constitutional right for East Pakistan to maintain its own paramilitary or militia force to secure its defenses.

Key Timeline & Major Milestones:

Feb 5, 1966	Sheikh Mujib introduces the Six Points at a national opposition conference in Lahore.
[Mar 18, 1966	Awami League formally adopts the program; mass public campaigns begin.
June 7, 1966	A nationwide general strike (Hartal) leads to the martyrdom of Bengali protesters.
1968 - 1969	West Pakistan responds with mass arrests and the Agartala Conspiracy Case.

- February 5, 1966: Sheikh Mujibur Rahman formally unveiled the formula at a national conference of opposition parties in Lahore. It was promptly rejected by West Pakistani politicians who labeled him a separatist.
- March 18, 1966: The Awami League formally approved the program, launching a massive grassroots campaign across East Pakistan.
- June 7, 1966: A historic nationwide general strike (*Hartal*) erupted to demand the release of arrested leaders. Police fired upon demonstrators, killing several individuals including Manu Mia, which permanently solidified June 7 as Historic Six-Point Day.

Core Comparison: Federal vs. Six-Point Structure

Governance Area	Existing Pakistani System (1966)	Demanded Six-Point Structure
Power Balance	Centralized military-civilian junta in West Pakistan.	Decentralized provincial autonomy under a direct democracy.
Monetary Control	Single central bank controlling wealth in West Pakistan.	Separate regional banking reserves/currencies to prevent capital flight.
Tax Revenues	Collected centrally; disproportionately spent in West Pakistan.	Managed entirely by provinces; federal government given a set share.
Defense Forces	Centrally directed army; left East Pakistan defenseless in 1965.	Autonomous local paramilitary and a naval headquarters in the East.

Historical Significance

The movement irreversibly transformed Bengali political sentiment. Instead of seeking minor policy adjustments within the framework of Pakistan, the populace united around the demand for complete self-determination. When the military regime attempted to suppress the movement by arresting Sheikh Mujib under the infamous Agartala Conspiracy Case, it triggered the 1969 Mass Uprising. This momentum carried directly into the Awami

League's landslide victory in the 1970 elections, laying the absolute geopolitical groundwork for the emergence of an independent Bangladesh in 1971.

The Six Points fundamentally reshaped the trajectory of the Bengali national identity and led to the creation of sovereign Bangladesh.

- **Catalyst for Political Awakening:** It galvanized the masses, shifting the political mindset from mere protest to active demands for self-determination and emancipation.
- **Rejection of Disparity:** It highlighted the systemic economic discrimination, where East Pakistan generated the majority of export income but received a disproportionately small share of federal spending.
- **The "Agartala Conspiracy" and Mass Uprising:** West Pakistan's refusal to accept these demands culminated in the imprisonment of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and the filing of the Agartala Conspiracy Case in 1968. This triggered mass student and public uprisings in 1969, which forced the military regime to drop the charges and release him as a national hero.
- **Blueprint for Independence:** The Six Points transformed the Awami League into the undisputed voice of the Bengalis. When the party won an absolute majority in the 1970 elections, the movement became the mandate for total independence, eventually sparking the 1971 Liberation War.